



THE FULL PLAYBOOK

Apply *Within.*

The complete guide to getting
the job you deserve.

LASZLO BOCK

Former SVP People Operations, Google

© 2026



BEFORE YOU READ

How to use *this playbook.*

Read in order — once.

The 8 chapters build on each other. Don't skip ahead.

Then jump back to what you need.

Updating your resume? Go to Chapter 2. Got an offer? Chapter 8.

Save it. Reference it.

You'll come back to it for every job change for the next decade.

Send it to someone.

It's free. Pay it forward.



Eight chapters.

In the order that works.

01 Hiring is rigged

Why the system isn't fair — and how to use that.

02 Your resume in one formula

The X/Y/Z rewrite that changes everything.

03 The cover letter trap

What to write. What to never write.

04 Networking without a network

Referrals get hired 5-10x more often.

05 The interview secret

Why "qualified" isn't enough.

06 Practice or perish

13.5 hours that separate winners from losers.

07 Land the interview, last

Why this comes seventh, not first.

08 Negotiate or lose

Your max leverage is the moment of the offer.

01

Hiring is rigged

Why the system isn't fair — and how to use that.



Hiring *is rigged.*

Here's how to win the game.

LASZLO BOCK

Former SVP People Operations, Google

SWIPE





The receipts.

30M+

resumes sifted by my team at Google

100K+

applicants I personally reviewed

1,000s

of people I interviewed face-to-face

I know what gets people hired. And what gets them rejected.



“

"We hire
only the best."

Also every company:

"Our hiring process is
exactly like everyone else's."

Hiring isn't about finding the best person.
It's about a tired manager picking someone who feels familiar —
fast.



This is *great news.*

If hiring were fair,
you'd have to be the most qualified person
in the room.

It isn't. So you don't.

**You don't need to be the best.
You need to know how the game is played.**



The only resume formula that works:

*Accomplished
[X] as measured by [Y]
by doing [Z]*

Decoded:



What you achieved



How you measured it (numbers, %, \$, time)



How you actually did it



Same person. Two resumes.



RESUME A

"Studied financial performance of companies and made investment recommendations."



RESUME B

*"Improved portfolio performance by **12% (\$1.2M)** over one year by refining cost of capital calculations and re-weighting portfolio based on resulting valuations."*



**Your goal isn't
to prove you can
do the job.**

**Your goal is to
get them to
*love you.***

People hire people they like.
Qualifications are a distant second.



12 questions you'll almost certainly be asked.

- 01** Tell me about yourself.
- 02** Why this role?
- 03** Why this company?
- 04** What's your greatest strength?
- 05** What's your greatest weakness?
- 06** Tell me about a time you led a team.
- 07** Tell me about a time you failed.
- 08** Tell me about a difficult coworker.
- 09** Why are you leaving your current job?
- 10** Where do you see yourself in 5 years?
- 11** What are your salary expectations?
- 12** Do you have any questions for us?

Write 2 answers each. Practice 3x out loud.



Always *negotiate.*

As long as you're polite, there's no risk.

Your max leverage is

the moment of the offer.

After you sign, it's gone forever.

The move:

A small increase in your offer compounds into big increases later.

Now go get the *job you deserve.*

01 SAVE THIS

You'll need it next time you job hunt.

02 SEND IT

To someone you know who's looking.

03 FOLLOW + COMMENT

Tell me your worst rejection story below.

COMING NEXT

Tomorrow: the resume formula.

02

Your resume in one formula

The X/Y/Z rewrite that changes everything.



58% OF RESUMES HAVE TYPOS.

100% OF BAD ONES HAVE

SOMETHING WORSE.

Your resume in one *formula.*

Lessons from reviewing 100,000 resumes at Google

SWIPE →



They list duties.

Not results.

A recruiter spends about 6 seconds on a resume.

Vague duties tell them nothing in 6 seconds. Numbers do.

WHAT VAGUE LOOKS LIKE

"Managed budget"

"Member of customer experience team"

"Helped lead key initiatives"



The only formula that works:

*Accomplished
[X] as measured by [Y]
by doing [Z]*

Decoded:



What you achieved



How you measured it (numbers, %, \$, time)



How you got it done



Same activity. Three rewrites.

ORIGINAL

"Managed sorority budget."

BETTER

*"Managed **\$31,000** Spring 2026 budget and invested idle funds."*

AWESOME

*"Managed **\$31,000** Spring 2026 budget and invested **\$10,000** in idle funds in high-yielding capital notes returning **5%** over the year."*

Same negotiation. Three rewrites.

ORIGINAL

"Responsible for negotiating service contract with Salesforce."

BETTER

*"Negotiated **30% (\$500k)** reduction in costs with Salesforce for post-delivery support."*

AWESOME

*"Negotiated **30% (\$500k)** reduction with Salesforce for post-delivery support by designing and using results from an **online auction of multiple vendors.**"*

5 formatting rules most people break.

01 Save as a PDF.

Other formats get mangled by recruiting software.

02 11pt minimum font size.

Smaller and recruiters can't read it.

03 ½" margins.

Tighter margins = more room for content.

04 No tables or columns.

Recruiting software breaks them.

05 Contact info on every page.

If a page gets separated, you're still findable.



One page *per decade.*

< 10 years experience → 1 page

> 10 years experience → 2 pages

*"I would have written you a shorter letter,
but I did not have the time."*

— Blaise Pascal



58%

of resumes have typos.

Yours can't be one of them.

Recruiters use typos as a fast filter to reject candidates. They have to — they get 250+ applications per role.

HOW TO ACTUALLY FIND THEM

Read your resume from the bottom up.

Then have a friend do the same.



Name-drop every brand *you can.*

People are biased towards recognizable brands.

Recruiters search their databases by company name.

Examples:

"Consulted to Pfizer"

"Supported supplier partnerships with Nike, Under Armour, Spanx"

"Led deployments of Salesforce and Workday"



97%

of Fortune 500 companies use AI
to screen resumes before a human sees them.

Three moves:

01 Mirror the job description's exact phrases in real bullets.

If the post says "stakeholder management," use that phrase.

02 Spell out acronyms once.

"Search Engine Optimization (SEO)" — both versions get matched.

03 Run it through a free ATS scanner.

Aim for 75%+ match. Try Jobscan, Resume Worded, Enhancv.

GPA and awards: tell the best, truthful story.

- ✓ GPA above 3.5 or top 10%
- ✓ It's OK to slice the data ("3.7 in my major") — but disclose it
- ✓ Awards — describe what they were for
- ✗ Anything below 3.5 — leave it off
- ✗ A trophy without context doesn't help you ("Won the Smith Prize" — for what?)



Hardships help you get into college.

They hurt you getting a job.

Three exceptions worth mentioning:

- Self-financed $\frac{1}{3}+$ of your education (loans count)
- Worked during school to pay for it
- First in your family to attend college

Everything else: leave it off your resume.

Don't lie.

Don't stretch.

Real people fired for resume lies:

The CEO of Yahoo

Fake computer science degree

The CFO of Veritas

Latin for "truth." You can't make this up.

Notre Dame's football coach

Lied about his academic and athletic background

MIT's Dean of Admissions

Forged her own academic record

Tomorrow:

the cover letter trap

(and why you should care less
about it than you think).

01 **SAVE THIS**

You'll need it tonight when you update your resume.

02 **SEND IT**

To anyone whose resume reads like a job description.

03 **FOLLOW**

So tomorrow's chapter shows up in your feed.

Comment your worst resume bullet — I'll rewrite the best ones.

03

The cover letter trap

What to write. What to never write.

Plot twist: Your outbound email is the modern cover letter!



You can't win a job with a cover letter.

But you can definitely
lose one.

After 30M resumes (and a lot of bad cover letters)

SWIPE →



The cover letter is *about defense.*

Your resume gets you the interview.

The cover letter just has to not screw it up.

DOWNSIDE RISKS THAT ACTUALLY GET YOU REJECTED

- A typo
- The wrong company name copied in by mistake
- Not customizing the letter
- Getting the hiring manager's name wrong when it's available

Cover letters that say

"Dear Hiring Manager" are

30%

more likely to get rejected.

The fix takes 90 seconds:

HOW

- If there's a human contact listed for the job, use their name. If it's a smaller company, use LinkedIn to find the recruiter or hiring manager.
- Check the company's careers page for a name.
- Triple-check the company name. Don't copy-paste.



Four paragraphs.

That's it.

01 **Introduce yourself**

One sentence. Who you are, what role, any connection (referral, friend of friend).

02 **Expand**

Three sentences max. Build on the intro. Don't repeat your resume.

03 **Why you, specifically**

Three sentences max. Reference something specific to this company — recent product, public statement, news.

04 **Promise to follow up**

Buys you the right to follow up later without feeling annoying.



Paragraph #3 makes you stand out.

Why? Because it's the only one that proves you actually researched the company.

WHAT "SPECIFIC" LOOKS LIKE

- A recent product launch
- A public statement from the CEO
- A new market they entered
- A challenge their industry just faced

AI can find these. You pick the one most relevant.



Customize *every time.*

A customized cover letter signals you put in real work.

A generic one signals you didn't.

THE WORKFLOW THAT WORKS

- Write one base letter that you're proud of.
- Use AI to customize paragraph 3 for each job.
- Read it once out loud before sending. Re-write it in your voice to catch typos and hallucinations.



Sign off.

Get out.

Include your contact info under your signature.

Don't sweat this.

The longer your cover letter, the more chances to mess it up.

Remember the goal:

First, do no harm.



If you have a referral, name them in *sentence one.*

Recruiters scan. They're looking for a reason to keep reading.

A name they recognize is the strongest reason.

(More on the network move in two days.)



**If you spend more
than 30 minutes on a
cover letter,
*you're doing it wrong.***

Spend that time on:

- **Your resume.**

It does the actual work.

- **Your network.**

Referrals get hired 5–10x more often.

- **Interview practice.**

30 questions, 3 reps each.



Plot twist:

Your outbound email is your cover letter.

Cover letters are far less common than they used to be.

But prospecting for a job via email is very common

All the cover letter principles apply to your email too.

Tomorrow:

network without networking

How referrals get hired 5–10x
more often than cold applications.

01 **SAVE THIS**

Pull it up next time you're applying.

02 **SEND IT**

To anyone agonizing over a cover letter.

03 **FOLLOW**

So tomorrow's chapter shows up.

04

Networking without a network

Referrals get hired 5-10x more often.



Networking without *a network*

You don't need a big network.

You don't need strong relationships.

You need one person.

From a refugee with no connections — to Google's
first SVP of People Operations

SWIPE →



5-10X

Referred candidates get hired

5 to 10 times more often

than cold applications.

This isn't fair.

It's also how every company works.



I came to the US as a refugee.

No network.

No idea what business was.

No idea who the big companies were.

HERE'S THE THING I LEARNED

The harder your story,
the more people want to help.



**You don't need
a connection.**

**You need
a connection
*to a connection.***

Where to look:

LinkedIn

Facebook

Instagram

Old emails

Group chats

A friend of yours who knows someone counts.



Ask for advice. *Not a job.*

Everyone wants to give advice.

The moment you ask for a job,
you become a problem to solve.
And most people quietly step away.

Ask for advice

and you'll get it — and sometimes, a job.

5 questions that get people hired.

01 How did you get your job?

Everyone loves telling their origin story.

02 What advice would you give someone trying to get into your field or company?

Their answer is usually the playbook for that company.

03 What parts of your company are hiring right now?

They might know about openings before they're posted.

04 Could you refer me to the recruiter?

Many companies pay employees referral bonuses.

05 Do you know someone else who could give me advice?

One conversation becomes three. Three becomes ten. One of those is hiring.



Manufacture *a coincidence* to make *a connection.*

Find one specific thing about them you can mention:

- A recent post they wrote
- A school you both went to
- A conference they spoke at
- A mutual connection
- A project or talk they shared

"I noticed..." beats "You don't know me, but..." every time.



The template that works:

Hi [Name] —

[Coincidence: I saw your post on... / We both went to...]

I'm exploring a move into [their field/company].

Would you be open to a 15-minute call?

I'd love your advice on how you got started.

Either way — thanks for the inspiration.

[Your name]

[Your contact info]



Show up *prepared.*

End on time.

If you said 15 minutes, end at 14.

Ask 2 specific questions.

Not "any advice?" — "how did you decide between X and Y?"

Send a thank-you.

Within 24 hours. Reference one specific thing they said.

Follow up a month later.

With what you did with their advice.

Start where *people gather.*

Free or cheap places to find your first connection:

Industry meetups

Search Eventbrite or Meetup for your city + field.

LinkedIn comments

Comment thoughtfully on posts from people in your target role.

Slack or Discord communities

Most industries have one. Join three. Be useful in two.

Alumni groups

School alumni clubs are designed for exactly this.



Make your list. Then — *don't reach out yet.*

If you reach out before your resume, your interview answers,
and your prep work are ready —

you throw away your shot.

You'll be ready to make contact after part 8.



People want *to help.*

More than you think.

Most people remember when they were stuck.

Most people remember someone helping them.

Most people want to pay it forward.

You just have to ask —

and ask the right question.

Tuesday:

the interview

secret most

candidates miss.

Hint: it's not about being qualified.

01 SAVE THIS

You'll need it before your next coffee chat.

02 SEND IT

To anyone who thinks they have no network.

03 FOLLOW

We're back Tuesday. The interview chapter.

05

The interview secret

Why "qualified" isn't enough.



Your goal isn't to prove you can do the job.

It's to get them to

love you.

SWIPE →



People hire *people they like.*

Qualifications are a distant second.

This isn't cynicism. It's data.

Most interview decisions are made in the first 4 minutes and then justified by what comes after. "Did I like them?" is the question your interviewer is actually answering.

If they love you, they'll forgive a lot.



Everyone you meet *is your interviewer.*

"What were they like in the lobby?"

This is a real interview question.

Hiring managers ask:

- Receptionists
- Admins
- People in the elevator
- Whoever offered you coffee

Be your kindest self with every single person you encounter.



Small talk *is the best talk.*

Stay off-topic for as long as you politely can.

Why? Because the interviewer doesn't get to make a friend with the next ten candidates. They get to make one with you.

How? Ask about the topics you put in your cover letter or intro email, or items in view behind them.

Don't worry —

they'll squeeze in the questions.



"You don't have the experience."

Don't fake it.

Reframe it.

"I haven't done this exact job before.

*If you need someone to recreate what everyone else is doing,
then I'm not your person.*

***But if you want someone who'll build something new,
I'm absolutely the right person.***

"The mechanics I haven't done are a phone call away. Real innovators are not."



That's the exact positioning that got me *hired onto Google's executive team at age 33.*

I had three years of HR experience.

Google wanted someone with 20.

I told them what they actually needed wasn't someone with 20 years of experience who would just duplicate their conventional, boring HR team. They needed someone who would build an HR team that nobody had.



The goal: nobody notices *your clothes.*

The trick:

Drive by the office the day before. See how people dress.

Then dress slightly better.

FOR VIDEO INTERVIEWS

- Virtual or blurred backdrop.
- Always use a ring light.
- Camera at eye level. Not below.

It might not *be with a human.*

More and more companies use AI interviewers
for at least the first round.

Treat it like a real interview.

Pretend you're talking to a friend.

Speak clearly, at a normal pace.

Most AIs transcribe first, evaluate second.

Use structure.

AI scoring rewards clear, organized answers.

Cluster Post-Its with your notes near the camera, not in a doc.

Eye movements are obvious to humans who review.



"Do you have any questions for me?"

The wrong answer:

"No, I think you covered everything."

The right answer:

"What does success look like in this role at the 6-month mark?"

"What's the biggest challenge the person in this role will face?"

"What didn't I ask that I should have?"

You want to demonstrate interest and keep the conversation rolling.



Send a thank-you

within 24 hours.

In fact, draft it before the interview.

That way you can fill in one specific thing they said.
And it lands within an hour, while you're still fresh in their mind.

DON'T FORGET

- Send one to every interviewer.
- Send one to the recruiter, too.
- Reference one specific thing each person said.

Five things that *slash your odds.*

- X Trash-talking your last employer**
Even if they deserve it. Especially if they deserve it.
- X Lying about a skill or experience**
It comes out in week 1. There's no week 2.
- X Showing up late**
There's no recovering. Always be there 15 minutes early.
- X Asking about salary first**
Wait until they bring it up.
- X No questions at the end**
Tells them you're not interested. Always have 3 ready.



**If they love you
but pass —
*they'll remember.***

This is the part most people miss.

If they liked you and the role wasn't right,
they'll think of you when the next one opens.

Every interview is a relationship, not a transaction.



Get them to *love you.*

Be kind in the lobby.

Make small talk.

Reframe what you don't have.

Ask great questions.

Send the thank-you.

That's it. That's the secret.

Thursday:

the practice protocol

How 13 hours of work separates the people who get jobs from the people who don't.

01 **SAVE THIS**

Pull it up before your next interview.

02 **SEND IT**

To anyone with an interview this month.

03 **FOLLOW**

We're back Thursday. The practice chapter.

06

Practice or perish

13.5 hours that separate winners from losers.



Doctor:

14 years.

Master plumber:

8 years.

Great job:

an afternoon.

If you put in the work.

SWIPE →



Interviews are *almost identical.*

Most interviewers ask the same questions.

Which is terrible for them.

And great for you.

If you can predict the questions,

you can prepare for them.



12 questions you'll almost certainly be asked.

- 01** Tell me about yourself.
- 02** Why this role?
- 03** Why this company?
- 04** What's your greatest strength?
- 05** What's your greatest weakness?
- 06** Tell me about a time you led a team.
- 07** Tell me about a time you failed.
- 08** Tell me about a difficult coworker.
- 09** Why are you leaving your current job?
- 10** Where do you see yourself in 5 years?
- 11** What are your salary expectations?
- 12** Do you have any questions for us?

Brainstorm the questions you think you'll get. Aim for 30.



Craft 2 answers *per question.*

"That's a lot of work."

Yes. Here's why it pays off:

Each interviewer is evaluating a different mix of attributes. Sometimes you nail it on the first try. Sometimes you don't.

When a second interviewer asks you a question you got before, give your second answer

Two answers ready means even when one doesn't land,
the next one might. That's often enough.



Every answer.

Same shape.

01 **Restate the question.**

Buys you 3 seconds to think.

02 **Summarize what you're about to say.**

Tells the listener exactly where you're going.

03 **Tell a story illustrating the trait.**

Specific, with numbers when possible.

04 **Summarize the story or insight again.**

Lands the point. Watch them think "good answer."

"Tell them what you'll say. Say it. Tell them what you said."



Practice each answer out loud. *3 times.*

Do the math:

30 questions

× 2 answers each

× 3 reps each

= 180 reps

≈ 13.5 hours of work

Spread over a week of evenings.

That's it. That's the entire investment.



"Won't I sound rehearsed?"

No.

Interviews are stressful enough that you won't come across as too polished.

People skip practice because they're afraid of sounding canned. So they sound terrible instead.

The few who practice get the jobs.



Practice *on real humans.*

A spouse. A friend. A roommate.

Anyone with two ears.

Why this beats solo practice:

- Saying it out loud to a face beats saying it to a wall.
- They'll tell you when you sound bored or boring.
- Their follow-up questions surface gaps you missed.
- It builds muscle for the actual interview.



Don't wait for the interview *to be scheduled.*

By the time you have an interview booked,
it's usually 3–7 days away.

That's not enough to do this work well.

Start the moment you start applying.



Update after *every interview.*

Within 30 minutes of every interview:

Write down every question you got.

Even the ones you nailed.

Score yourself out of 10.

Be honest. The misses teach you the most.

Add new questions to your list.

Each interview can surface 2-3 you didn't predict.

Rewrite your weakest answers.

Practice them once before bed.

Most people don't put in *the work.*

The ones who do —

Get more interviews.

Get more offers.

Get better jobs.

Which of these two people do you want to be?

Tuesday:

the step you should do LAST (not first).

There's a reason I saved this for chapter 7.

It's not what you think.

01 **SAVE THIS**

You'll need it before your next interview.

02 **SEND IT**

To anyone interviewing in the next two weeks.

03 **FOLLOW**

We're back Tuesday. The big reveal.

07

Land the interview, last

Why this comes seventh, not first.



You've read six chapters before this one.

On purpose.

If you'd applied to your dream job in week 1,
your odds would have been way worse.

You weren't ready. But now you are.

SWIPE →



Practice in the minor *leagues first.*

What you don't want:

Get an interview at your dream company.

Get blindsided by a question.

Walk out knowing you blew it.

Now you know why this chapter is chapter 7.



Start with your *B-tier companies*

Not your dream companies.

Not your easy lateral moves.

The ones in the middle.

Why this works:

- You'll fine-tune your resume on lower-stakes interviews.
- If you fall in love with one and they love back — that's not bad!
- An offer here gives you leverage with the A companies.



Now — contact *your network.*

Remember the list of connections you made in chapter 4?

This is where it pays off.

Your resume is sharp. Your interview answers are ready. You can speak fluently about why this company, why this role.

Now you're ready to ask for the introduction.



Apply to way more jobs than *you think.*

Industry rough math:

100 applications

= about 5 first-round interviews

5 first rounds

= about 1-2 final rounds

1-2 final rounds

= about 1 offer

*If you've applied to 10 jobs and given up,
you haven't started.*



Apply directly.

Always PDF.

Apply through the company's site.

Third-party portals can mangle formatting. The company assumes it's your error.

Submit a PDF, never a Word doc.

PDFs preserve everything. Word files render differently in different ATS systems.

Apply to multiple jobs at the same company.

Different recruiters screen different roles. One of them might love you.

If silence after 3 months, reapply.

Refresh your resume first. The role pool resets.



Follow up. *Always.*

Every 2 weeks. For 6 weeks.

You earned this right in your cover letter (chapter 3). Use it.

WHAT TO SAY

*"I hope you won't mind my persistence —
I care deeply about this company.
Just wanted to confirm my application is
still on your list to review."*

Expect silence. Expect rejection. *Don't take it personally.*

From the recruiter's side:

They get more applications than they could ever read.

Their goal is to talk to as few people as possible to fill the job,
not to be polite to every applicant.

The silence is impersonal. Persevere and follow-up.



Track everything *in one spreadsheet.*

Six columns. That's all you need:

<u>01</u>	<u>02</u>	<u>03</u>	<u>04</u>	<u>05</u>	<u>06</u>
Company	Role	Date first applied	Contact	Status	Last touch
			<i>Recruiter or Hiring manager or Referrer</i>	<i>Applied or Interviewed or Offer or Closed</i>	<i>Date of most recent action</i>

Without this, it's easy to let an opportunity drop.



3-6 months

is normal.

From the day you start applying
to the day you sign an offer.

During that time, expect:

- More rejection than you've ever received.
- Long stretches of complete silence.
- Roles that ghost you mid-process.
- At least one company you really wanted says no.

This is the job. Expect it. Plan for it.



Applying isn't the start.

It's the finish.

By the time you click "submit,"
you've already done the hard work.

Thursday:

the negotiation move that adds five figures.

*If you only read one chapter,
read this one.*

01 **SAVE THIS**

Pull it up when you're applying for real.

02 **SEND IT**

To anyone agonizing over rejection emails.

03 **FOLLOW**

We're back Thursday. Money chapter.

08

Negotiate or lose

Your maximum leverage is the moment of the offer.



Always *negotiate.*

As long as you're polite,
there's no risk.

There's only the money you
leave on the table by not asking.

SWIPE →



Your maximum leverage is at the moment *of the offer.*

Before the offer, you have nothing.

After you sign, you're an employee.

Just like everyone else.

Between those two moments,

you have all the power.



Don't seem *greedy.*

They've already chosen you.

Coming across as ungrateful, demanding, or transactional can lose the offer. It's rare. It happens.

ONE EXCEPTION

Sales and similar roles.

There, hard negotiation can be taken as a positive signal — evidence you'll do the same for the company. (Just don't be a jerk.)

Get two offers.

Play them off.

By far the most effective tactic.

It leaves you as the innocent actor — you're just sincerely weighing two real options.

WHY THIS WORKS

This is exactly why chapter 7 said:

Start with B-tier companies.

A B-company offer is the best leverage you'll ever have at an A.



Argue as a *shared decision.*

It's harder for them to negotiate with someone who isn't in the room.

EXAMPLE:

*"My partner and I sat down last night, and we're just trying to make this work with everything else going on. Is there **any flexibility on the base salary?**"*



Use real-life *obligations.*

Easy things for a hiring manager to sympathize with:

Higher cost of living in a new area

If you're relocating, the math is the math.

Student debt to pay off

Specific numbers help. "\$72,000 in loans" lands better than "loans."

Supporting a parent, charity, or other relatives

Real, sympathetic, and impossible to argue with.

IMPORTANT:

Like I wrote in chapter 2:

Don't ever lie.

You mom raised you better than that.



Salary is the obvious ask. *It's not the only one.*

Other things you can ask for:

- Sign-on bonus
- Equity / stock refresh
- Extra (informal) vacation days
- Remote/flex work arrangement
- Earlier review for next raise
- Relocation assistance

If they say no on salary, ask for some other type of compensation.



Know your *number.*

Before you start any negotiation:

Know the market range to inform your ask.

Use Levels.fyi, Glassdoor, Payscale, plus 2-3 friends in similar roles.

Know the ranges by component.

Base, bonus, equity. Each has different flexibility.

Know your walk-away number.

This is the lowest you'd say yes to. Don't reveal it.

Know your ask number.

10-20% above the offer is the standard ask. More is plausible if data supports it.



Let them offer *a number first.*

If you go first, that's the maximum.

If they go first, that's the minimum

If asked "what are your salary expectations?", deflect:

THREE WAYS TO DEFLECT

→ *"What's the budget for this role?"*

→ *"I'd love to hear what you've allocated."*

→ *"I'm flexible — what's the range?"*

If pressed, give a wide range, anchored at your ask.



Get it *in writing.*

Verbal offers are not offers.

Until you have a written offer letter, the negotiation isn't real and the offer can disappear.

Get any promises they made written into the offer letter.

Keep interviewing elsewhere at least until you've signed your offer.

Once it's signed, anything not in writing

doesn't exist.

\$1M+

**is the lifetime cost
of skipping the conversation.**

A \$5,000 raise at age 25, compounded over 40 years
of standard 3% annual raises and a modest investment
return — that's a million dollars by retirement.

ASK FOR THE RAISE.

It's not just this paycheck.



If you don't ask, the answer *is always no.*

If you ask politely, prepared, and with leverage —
the answer is yes more often than you think.

And every yes is worth tens of thousands of dollars.

Be polite. Be prepared. Always ask.

Now go get the job *you deserve.*

01 SAVE THE WHOLE SERIES

Every chapter is on my profile.

02 SHARE IT

Send it to someone who needs it.

03 FOLLOW

The full playbook drops next Tuesday.

COMING TUESDAY: THE FULL 100+ PAGE PLAYBOOK

Hiring is a rigged game that ***You can win.***

You don't have to be the most qualified.

You don't have to know the right people.

You don't have to come from the right background.

You just have to know how the game is played.

Now you do.



STAY IN TOUCH

Now go get the job *you deserve.*

If this helped you —

Send it to someone job-hunting.

Tell me your story.

Pay it forward.

LASZLO BOCK · [linkedin.com/in/laszlobock](https://www.linkedin.com/in/laszlobock)